LilyPond chordmode chords

Oct 20, 2026 · @Geb

Syntax

In `\chordmode`, a chord is a root, an optional duration, then a colon and modifiers: `c4:m7`. Without a colon it is a major triad; a duration carries over to later chords that omit one. Chords are written in absolute pitch names (Dutch by default: `cis` is C#, `ees` is E♭).

```
\chordmode { c1 c:m c:7 c:maj7 }
```

The general shape is `root[duration]:quality[number][additions][^removals][/bass]`. Use `\new ChordNames` to print the symbols and `\new Staff` to print the notes.

Chord qualities

Each quality is shown on C. Replace `c` with any root (`fis:m7`, `bes:maj7`).

Chord	LilyPond	Notes
Major	`c`	C E G
Minor	`c:m`	C E♭ G
Diminished	`c:dim`	C E♭ G♭
Augmented	`c:aug`	C E G♯
Suspended 2nd	`c:sus2`	C D G
Suspended 4th	`c:sus4`	C F G
Power chord	`c:5`	C G
Sixth	`c:6`	C E G A
Minor sixth	`c:m6`	C E♭ G A
Dominant seventh	`c:7`	C E G B♭
Major seventh	`c:maj7`	C E G B

Chord	LilyPond	Notes
Minor seventh	`c:m7`	C E♭ G B♭
Minor-major seventh	`c:m7+`	C E♭ G B
Diminished seventh	`c:dim7`	C E♭ G♭ B𝄫
Half-diminished	`c:m7.5-`	C E♭ G♭ B♭
Seventh sus4	`c:7sus4`	C F G B♭
Dominant ninth	`c:9`	C E G B♭ D
Major ninth	`c:maj9`	C E G B D
Minor ninth	`c:m9`	C E♭ G B♭ D
Dominant eleventh	`c:11`	C G B♭ D F (the third is dropped automatically)
Dominant thirteenth	`c:13`	C E G B♭ D A

Additions, alterations, removals and bass notes

After the quality, steps are separated by dots. A `+` raises a step by a semitone, a `-` lowers it. A caret `^` removes steps. A slash sets the bass.

Goal	LilyPond	Notes
Add a ninth to a triad	`c:3.5.9`	C E G D
Added sixth and ninth	`c:6.9`	C E G A D
Flat ninth	`c:7.9-`	C E G B♭ D♭
Sharp ninth	`c:7.9+`	C E G B♭ D♯
Raised fifth	`c:7.5+`	C E G♯ B♭
Lowered fifth	`c:7.5-`	C E G♭ B♭
Sharp eleventh	`c:maj7.11+`	C E G B F♯
Remove the third	`c:7^3`	C G B♭
Remove fifth and third	`c:9^3.5`	C B♭ D

Goal	LilyPond	Notes
First inversion	`c/e`	E C G (bass E)
Second inversion	`c/g`	G C E (bass G)
Bass note added, nothing moved	`c/+g`	G C E G
Minor seventh over a bass	`c:m7/bes`	B♭ C E♭ G

Example: ii–V–I in C with chord names

The same `chordmode` music feeds both the chord symbols and the staff.

```
harmony = \chordmode {
  d1:m7 g:7 c:maj7 a:7.9-
}

\score {
  <<
    \new ChordNames \harmony
    \new Staff { \harmony }
  >>
}
```

In musics, import real LilyPond text with `musics.input.lilypond-import`; GUIDO accidentals replace the Dutch suffixes (see `doc/md/lilypond.md`).

Blues chorus: 12 bars in C

The basic blues is three four-bar phrases on I, IV and V, all dominant sevenths. The quick change (F7 in bar 2) and the V in the last bar are the common variants.

Bar	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Chord	C7	F7	C7	C7	F7	F7	C7	C7	G7	F7	C7	G7

```
bluesChorus = \chordmode {
  c1:7 f:7 c:7 c:7
  f:7 f:7 c:7 c:7
  g:7 f:7 c:7 g:7
}

\score {
  <<
    \new ChordNames \bluesChorus
    \new Staff { \bluesChorus }
  >>
}
```

Jazz chorus: rhythm changes in B♭

The 32-bar AABA form from "I Got Rhythm" is the standard jazz chorus. The A section circles I–vi–ii–V; the bridge is a cycle of dominants (D7–G7–C7–F7), two bars each.

Section	Bars	Chords
A (×3)	1–2	B♭maj7 G7 | Cm7 F7
	3–4	Dm7 G7 | Cm7 F7
	5–6	Fm7 B♭7 | E♭maj7 E°7
	7–8	Dm7 G7 | Cm7 F7 (last A: B♭maj7)
B (bridge)	17–24	D7 | G7 | C7 | F7, two bars each

```
rhythmA = \chordmode {
  bes2:maj7 g:7 c:m7 f:7
  d:m7 g:7 c:m7 f:7
  f:m7 bes:7 ees:maj7 e:dim7
  d:m7 g:7 c:m7 f:7
}

rhythmB = \chordmode {
  d1:7 d:7 g:7 g:7 c:7 c:7 f:7 f:7
}

rhythmChanges = { \rhythmA \rhythmA \rhythmB \rhythmA }

\score {
  <<
    \new ChordNames \rhythmChanges
    \new Staff { \rhythmChanges }
  >>
}
```

The `\chordmode` variables hold chords, so `rhythmChanges` joins them with plain braces. Change the last bar of the final `\rhythmA` to `bes1:maj7` to end on the tonic.

Jazz ii–V–I turnaround chorus in C

The ii–V–I is jazz's basic cadence. This 8-bar chorus plays it four times with the usual substitutions, so each pass sounds different while the harmony stays in C.

Bars	Chords	Variant
1–2	Dm7 G7 | Cmaj7	Plain ii–V–I
3–4	Dm7 G7 | Cmaj7 A7♭9	Secondary dominant leads back to the ii
5–6	Dm7 G7 | Cmaj7	Plain again
7–8	Dm7 D♭7 | Cmaj7 G7	Tritone substitution, then a turnaround

```
iiVIChorus = \chordmode {
  d2:m7 g:7  c1:maj7
  d2:m7 g:7  c:maj7 a:7.9-
  d2:m7 g:7  c1:maj7
  d2:m7 des:7  c:maj7 g:7
}

iiVIMinor = \chordmode {
  d2:m7.5- g:7.9-  c1:m6
}

\score {
  <<
    \new ChordNames { \iiVIChorus \iiVIMinor }
    \new Staff { \iiVIChorus \iiVIMinor }
  >>
}
```

The minor version (`iiVIMinor`) swaps in a half-diminished ii, a flat-nine V and a minor-sixth tonic. The tritone substitute `des:7` shares its third and seventh with `g:7`, so it resolves to C the same way.